Fernwood Project - Contributor Guide

Getting started and branches

Fork the repository and create a topic branch from the main branch. Branch names follow the pattern type/short-description, for example fix/null-pointer-on-login or feature/csv-export. Run the full test suite locally with make test before opening a pull request. Commit messages use the imperative mood, such as 'Add retry logic', and the first line must not exceed 72 characters. Large changes should be split into several small commits, each of which builds and passes the tests.

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Code review

Every pull request needs at least two approving reviews, one of which must come from a maintainer listed in the CODEOWNERS file. The continuous integration checks must pass before merging. Reviewers aim to respond within three working days; if nobody responds after five working days, the author may ping the maintainers channel. Authors should not force-push to a branch after the review has started, because this makes it hard to see what changed. Pull requests are merged with the squash strategy so that the main branch keeps a linear history.

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Releases and security

Fernwood follows semantic versioning. A new minor release is published on the first Tuesday of every month, and patch releases are made whenever a security fix is merged. Release candidates are tagged with the suffix -rc followed by a number and are tested for one week before the final release. The changelog is generated from the pull request titles, so titles should describe the user-visible change. Security vulnerabilities must not be reported in public issues; send a private report to the security contact listed in SECURITY.md, and expect an acknowledgement within 48 hours.